

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-10-06

1 following update on recent developments in iran.

A new, two-pronged assault was launched against the iranian bahá'í

community during the last week. one was aimed at stultifying academic

2 educational activities among the bahá'ís; the other was a further attempt at

3 destabilizing bahá'í families.

more than 36 faculty members of the bahá'í institute of higher educa-

4 tion (bihe) were reported to have been arrested between 29 September and 286.5

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288 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

289 6503 october in cities across the country. it is understood that most of these

290 have now been released, but that five in Tabriz and two in Tehran remain

291 in custody. The arrests were carried out by officers of the iranian govern-

292 ment's intelligence agency, the ministry of information, and also involved

293 the seizure of textbooks, scientific papers and documentary records, some

70 computers, and items of furniture useful to students, including tables

71 and benches. Those arrested were asked to sign a document declaring that

72 bihe had ceased to exist as of 29 September and undertaking that they would no longer cooperate with it. The detainees refused to sign any such declaration.

raids on more than 500 bahá'í homes added to the harassment suffered

73 by bahá'ís throughout iran at the hands of intelligence officers. when que-

74 ried about the seizure of personal household effects like television sets and

75 pieces of furniture, these officers claimed that they had been authorized by

76 the Attorney-g eneral to take anything they wished.

The wave of arrests and harassment bears the marks of a centrally or-

77 chestrated campaign intended to lend impetus to the declared policy of the
78 iranian government to nullify the bahá'í community and force its members
79 to convert to islam. This policy became widely known in 1993 when it was
80 accidentally revealed that the iranian Supreme revolutionary council had
81 earlier adopted a position on "the bahá'í question" in a secret document

dated 25 february 1991 and signed by Ayatollah khamenei. The document

82 contained such declarations as the following:

The government's dealings with them must be in such a way that

83 their progress and development are blocked.

They must be expelled from universities, either in the admission pro-

84 cess or during the course of their studies, once it becomes known that

85 they are b ahá'ís.

A plan must be devised to confront and destroy their cultural roots

86 outside the country.

87 deny them employment if they identify themselves as b ahá'ís.

deny them any position of influence, such as in the educational sec-

tor, etc.287 .4

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288 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

289 651it is evident that the iranian government has worked at various means to
290 achieve these ends; among them are the banning of the administrative insti-
291 tutions of the faith, the disruption of the moral education classes for bahá'í

children and young people, the economic strangulation of the bahá'ís

292 through such means as the dismissal of bahá'í employees, the denial of

293 pensions and the confiscation of properties, and the prohibition of bahá'í
294 youth from entering institutions of higher learning in iran. The recent at-
295 tacks by iranian authorities can be viewed as effecting only a part of this
296 policy.

Department of tHe secretariat

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Appeal Submitted to Supreme Court

for Bahá'ís Imprisoned in Iran

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]